

Chapter III

Enemies In The Shadows

A dreamless sleep followed the night of celebrations. Of all the compounding memories of the night before, his argument with Iya is the most painful. As he stands in front of the door to the House of the High, he goes over the words he should not have said. And which ones he should have.

He was angry at the time. But only because he felt as though the one person who understood him was leaving him behind. He should find her, Oberon thinks. After the meeting, he should find her and apologise.

Oberon releases a long sigh. He reaches for the door handle, but before he can turn it the door swings open. Oberon is met with the broad smile of his older brother. Tall and broad at the shoulders. His electric blue eyes glimmer with confidence. Triton is six years older than Oberon, so he has always had this aura of expertise and comfort that Oberon has never felt. But he doesn't quite have the bulk of muscles that Oberon has. His brother has had some training with the sword, but only a stretch in the military can give you a warrior's build.

"Brother!" Triton calls cheerily, pulling Oberon into a tight hug, "Eavesdropping in the hallway again, aye? Thought you had grown out of that creepy little habit."

"Shut it." Oberon replies with a grumble, though he couldn't help but smile. Triton tends to have that effect on people. "I wasn't..."

Before he can get the words out, Galeedeus clears his throat, quieting the two of them. Oberon finally gets a good look inside. The House of the High is a circular chamber in one of the White Towers. Its walls are wooden and carved with detailed representations of the High Gods. Except for Tiera, Ra'Kax, and Obdulām, who are depicted in the large, ornate stained-glass window on the end of the room.

A five meter wide stone table rests in the centre of the chamber, surrounded by thirteen chairs, usually meant to host the twelve High Conduits, and the King. Five of the chairs are full currently. Around the table each member of the Protivera family sits in order of their age. Triton takes his seat by the window next to Galeedeus, who is

dressed in a freshly steamed military uniform, his boots as well polished as the side sword on his belt. To the side of Triton sits his older sister Rhea. She is thin and draped with the newest fashions of Hylestus, more of those tight gowns and ugly colours that irritate Oberon so. With a sick feeling he notices that she is even wearing her hair in a high braid similar to Myra's.

Rhea stands and rushes over to wrap Oberon in a tight embrace. "Oh, Oberon," she squeals in a high octave, "Congratulations on your promotion! A Royal Knight! I can hardly believe it!"

Oberon mutters a thank you and tries to pry his sister off of him. When she eventually relents, still beaming up at him, his second youngest sister, Erinome stands as well.

She is the closest to Oberon's age by only a couple of years, but far less experienced with the outside world. She is dressed in simple Devotee robes, with her hair in a tight bun, and her face in rested contemplation.

"I am glad to see you have chosen to walk a path of virtue, brother." Her voice is measured and emotionless, "I had worried that the light of the Gods may have dimmed in your soul while you were so far from home. But, I can see that my prayers were answered."

His youngest sister, Elara, does not stand alongside Erinome. She sits at the end of the table, her black hair cut short, in the hunter's way, cleaning her nails with a dirty skinning knife. She gives Oberon a half-hearted nod without making eye contact.

"Sit down, all of you." Galeedeus commands flatly.

Everyone is quick to obey the order. Rhea rushes back to her seat, still smiling amiably. Erinome places herself back down gracefully. And Triton kicks his feet up on the table, which scores an irritated glare from Galeedeus.

Oberon's chair is a little too small for him to easily seat himself in his plate armour. The creaking of wood and scraping of metal does not go unnoticed. In fact his whole family looks at him curiously. Except Triton, who smiles widely.

"Son," Galeedeus drolls with a wry tone, "I don't think this is the place for armour. Right now, it is not the best look for you to visit your family in such attire."

Oberon shrugs. "It's a habit at this point."

Galeedeus doesn't react with the sternness that Oberon expects. Instead he just watches Oberon for a while, before waving his hand dismissively and turning to Triton.

Triton, still smirking, slaps his thigh jovially. "Right, now that we are all accounted for shall we tell everyone why they are here, Father? Or do you intend to leave them in suspense a little longer?"

"Yes, I suppose it is time." grumbles Galeedeus, "Children, it has become apparent to me over the past year that my position as Lord Protector of Harkon is threatened."

Oberon jumps at this announcement, and his siblings look just as shocked as he feels. They are one of the most powerful families in Ono-Kām, the King's own chosen warriors. They all shared anxious glances, except for Triton who, oddly enough, looks rather bored.

"Threatened?" Rhea queries, "In what way?"

"In the way that ends in my, and most likely your, death. The way that leaves our home to thieves, and our people to vultures. There are plots. Schemes, made by the wolves of the court, to lessen our hold on the region. And plans to find another to take my place." Galeedeus states bluntly. He stands and moves to peer through the window, down at the city below.

"How do you know this?" Rhea pries, gripping the edge of the table tight.

Galeedeus doesn't answer, he just keeps watching the streets below. Triton takes a deep breath and speaks in his place.

"I discovered it." He admits, "My time in the courts has landed me with many knowledgeable friends. These friends of mine have been feeding me information from the other Houses, and from inside the King's own council."

"And they're plotting a takeover?" Rhea presses.

"The Houses have been preparing for something. Placing soldiers, meeting in secret, bribing High Conduits. And it all seems to be pointing towards Harkon. Towards the House Protivera." Triton concludes, a serious tone replacing his light-hearted demeanor.

“But is there any evidence that there is a scheme specifically against our House? Plots are plentiful in the Capitol, after all. Couldn’t there be many other reasons for their secrecy?” Erinome inquires, impassively. She looks undisturbed at the news. Oberon has always seen the same quiet stoicism in her that their father has.

“No,” Galeedeus cuts in, “They are making a move against us. Our House has had a difficult history with the Vienna Family. Your uncle refused to aid Nero in his rebellion, until the war came to our homeland. His most devoted loyalists wanted Protivera rule deposed because of that. If not for my brother’s sacrifice during the Battle of Hylestus, Nero may have done just that.”

He finally turns away from the window. With heavy, rhythmic steps he approaches the table. Galeedeus towers over his seated children. Even being a veteran of a hundred battles, and being responsible for the millions that live in Harkon, his stature is one of raw strength and will. Everyone in the room knows this side of their father. When he has identified a threat, all should fear.

“Times are changing. Houses that were once irrelevant are gaining power. They play the game of politics. They are making deals, securing territory, ensuring that they use the fog of war to expand their influence.”

Galeedeus grows quiet. Leaning on the table, he stares into nothingness, and contemplates. No one dares interrupt. With a deep breath, he closes his eyes.

“I wanted to ensure that our family’s relationship with the Throne was strong. I did what I thought would secure our safety. Throughout this unending campaign I have provided the King with everything he has asked for and more. Soldiers, Riders, ships, provisions. Everything that I could offer.

“I weakened us. I sent our fighters to die in Nero’s war. I thinned our fleet. I tainted the morale of our people. I wasn’t ensuring our security. I was ensuring our demise.”

Silence befalls the room as all take in these words. Rhea’s mouth hangs open, and Elara gets up from her chair to start pacing around the chamber. Oberon sinks as deep into his chair as his armour allows.

He is unsettled to find that this news doesn't come as much of a surprise to him. When Oberon joined the army he had noticed that his name had less pull than he had expected. In fact, Oberon remembers that he had been given duties far below his station at first. It is likely that his friendship with Iya, and his proficiency for violence, were the only reasons he was given more than banner bearing.

"Who are *they* anyway?" frets Elara, still pacing around the back of the room.

"Not many specific names to be honest," Triton sighs, "Nuariveran Lords are tricky. They have had plenty of practice acting like snakes in the grass. But, there is one Harkon House I know for certain is involved. The Morst family."

Rhea scoffs. "Well that's not a surprise. Those bastards have been lusting after our power for years. And they are so far into Nero's bed they may as well marry him."

"Not just lusting." notes Triton, "They have purchased mines, agricultural land, and have trained a rather impressive force of soldiers. They have become a real threat."

Erinome shakes her head and looks at Galeedeus.

"The King gave you the position of Lord Protector after the loss of your brother." She rebuts calmly, "Surely he hasn't recanted on that decision?"

"No, he has not, thank the Gods." Galeedeus grunts, "We still have his support, and I doubt he has plans to remove me."

"It would be a bad move if he did." adds Triton, "If Nero were to openly renounce an ancient House, who have never acted against his interests, other families would wonder if they could be next in line to the chopping block."

Rhea lets out a short, high-pitched squeal of a laugh. "Well, there you have it. What do we have to worry about with the King on our side? Simply tell him all these little secrets Triton has uncovered, and get him to sort the traitors out."

"Running to the King would make us look even more weak," Triton responds, sounding more serious than before, "We need to deal with these issues ourselves, or risk giving our enemies more reason to eliminate us."

Galeedeus nods sharply. "I agree. We must handle this on our own."

"The rebels are our enemies!" Oberon blurts out. All heads turn to look at him curiously. Galeedeus raises an eyebrow. "The rebels, the bandits, the Sorvs, the Old

Army. They are the enemies of the Throne. They are who we fight, who we are meant to be fighting. We are at war, we shouldn't be trying to pick fights with other Houses."

Triton cringes and shakes his head at Oberon, but it's too late. Galeedeus slowly walks over to stand above Oberon. He speaks in a low, steady voice.

"War? Is that what you call those little skirmishes on our borders? The real war was won three decades ago. The conflicts in the south are just to keep the leaders of Nuarivera, and Harkon distracted."

Galeedeus leans in closer, "The Sorvs keep to themselves, and are far away from here. And the Old Army hasn't made an attack on our people since the real war ended. And the rebels? They all died a long time ago. The Jakan asked for peace a long time ago. Our real enemies are here. They walk the same streets as us, they eat at our tables, they scheme in the shadows.

"The day Nero took the throne every High Lord and Lady strove to grab more power than they had while under Luxiveran rule. That contest hasn't stopped or slowed."

Galeedeus rises and moves back to the window. He takes another silent moment as he observes all the little people below.

"Your time in the army has made you blind to the reality of our world."

Oberon stands and storms across the room to face his father. A rising, boiling makes his muscles twitch, ready for violence. Triton rises slowly, watching Oberon carefully.

"They've asked for peace!" Oberon growls. The shock of the revelation runs through his veins like lava. "Peace? They are out for our blood. Their loyalty to the Luxiveran's still held strong. They told us that they needed to die, before they killed us! That's why we must be forever on guard, forever vigilant."

"Forever distracted." Galeedeus cuts in, "Distracted by war while the wolves draw ever near."

Oberon doesn't believe him. He can't. How can it be that all this time, while he suffered and sacrificed, the rebels had asked for peace? For three years he marched in that campaign. For three years he witnessed the horrors an unleashed force can reap upon

disadvantaged foe. Three years away from home, away from his family, away from his life. They would not take that from him over some petty jealousies.

“The King swore an oath too,” he hisses through gritted teeth, “He swore to honour us, as we honour him.”

“Nuariverans don’t know what honour is, Oberon.” Triton says in a hushed voice. “And it’s rare to find in a Harkon now too.”

Oberon shakes his head, his gauntleted knuckles clenched and trembling. The one thing that had kept him going during the campaign was the knowledge that his actions were for the greater good. That with every life was taken for a purpose.

“Your brother is right,” grumbles Galeedeus. “Honour matters little these days. Only strength has value.”

Oberon glares at his father. Once the General of his brother’s army, then made to rule in his place. Galeedeus was said to be a pillar of honour. An icon for the Harkon to look to when times were darkest. Oberon knew that version of this man for a short time. Now he finds himself looking at a man he doesn’t recognise.

His father stares back at him. He shows no reaction to Oberon’s fury, just patience.

Oberon goes back to the table, and slumps back down into his chair. After a moment of stillness, Galeedeus approaches his son, and places a hand on his armoured shoulder.

“Children, we have been weak.” he announces with ferocity, “That weakness has incited the vultures to circle. Harkon is our home. So, we will show all who challenge us the true strength of House Protivera! We will show them what happens when wolves meet griffons!”

Elara stops pacing, and Rhea sits forward in her chair.

“When?” Erinome asks.

“Tonight.” Galeedeus responds.

That causes an air thick tension. The siblings glance across the table at one another, all showing faces of deep concern.

“Tonight? So soon?” Rhea quavers.

“Yes, tonight.” Galeedeus affirms, stalking around the table. “It is our best opportunity. Leaders from all the Houses are here, including those of our enemies, whomever they may be. They will not expect us to make such a public move, and thus will have no time to prepare. This gives us the advantage. Tonight we shall strike.”

“Father,” Erinome utters softly, “Attacking other Houses, while many of their troops wait in the city, and after they have been granted protection by the King... Well, it would not only be dangerous, but it would be breaking the very laws that bind us together. The Gods will not favour us if we partake in such a malicious action. And the High Conduits have the power to denounce you, even if the King tried to intervene.”

“Oh we won’t be swinging a sword wildly at anyone who looks at as funny, dear sister.” chuckles Triton, “I assure you that our plan is a bit more elegant than that.”

“So there is a plan then?” presses Rhea.

“Indeed. Our main issue is that, although we know we have enemies, we do not know who they are. They are shrouded in a veil of gossip and lies. So, to get the honey we must shake the hive.” As he finishes speaking Triton turns to father.

Galeedeus stops at the head of the table, and looks each of his children in the eyes. He speaks clearly, “Tonight, I will demand a Contest of Honour against House Morst. Against High Lord Ivox Morst, specifically. I will accuse him of him plotting to steal my land and its wealth during the feast. High Lords and Ladies from across Ono-Kām will be there to witness the challenge. I will demand justice for his crimes in the fighting pit.”

“Ivox?” Rhea asks sceptically, “He must be in his seventies by now. He is sure to refuse. He will nominate someone to take his place.”

Rhea exchanges a nervous glance with Erinome. Triton just holds out his arms, a devilish grin across his face.

“He will nominate his son. The Bloody Butcher himself. Sir Anton Morst. And we will nominate our own champion.” He exclaims.

Oberon feels a cold sweat pass over him at the mention of the name. Sir Anton Morst. One of the most, if not the most, terrifying fighters in all of Harkon. Nearly seven feet tall, built like a watch tower, and with a reputation for violence exceeding Ro, the God of War himself. Oberon sighs deeply.

“I’ll do it.” he mutters.

To his surprise, Triton laughs.

“Ha! Come now brother, we wouldn’t throw you in the arena with that ugly mutt.” he chuckles.

Oberon looks up confused. He was sure it would be him. The third born kin is always the warrior. Always the one sent to defend a House.

“You are too important, son.” Galeedeus agrees, “I will not risk your life against that monster of a man.”

Relief washed over Oberon. He would have been ready to do whatever it took to save his family, but the thought of being trapped in a deathmatch with the War Dog was enough to make anyone want to flee for the hills.

“If not me, then who?” Oberon asked.

“That’s my little secret, brother.” Triton says with a cheerful wink. “Got someone who is sure to impress.”

Galeedeus nods and addresses the room once more.

“Today, all I ask of you all is to stay alert, make no inappropriate displays before or during the feast, and keep out of trouble. The plan is already in motion, and your parts will come later. Dismissed.”

And with that he turns back to the window.

No one says another word. It is generally accepted that when Galeedeus Protivera dismisses you, you leave with haste. But as his siblings file out of the door Oberon hesitates. He waits for the last of his family to leave. Triton shoots him a questioning look as he closes the door behind him, but Oberon ignores him.

“I hope you listen to your superior’s orders better than you listen to mine, son.” Galeedeus mutters, still gazing out the window.

Oberon doesn’t answer, instead he moves to stand beside his father. Through the glass of the tower the city of Hylestus is sprawled below. The buildings lay in twelve circular patterns, with large intricately chiselled statues at the centre of each. Each depicts one of the twelve High Gods. Even from up here he can see the sunlight glinting off their golden crowns.

“This place isn’t good for you, Father.” Oberon says bitterly.

Galeedeus doesn’t respond immediately. He continues to watch the city below. Now that he is calm Oberon can see just how tired the man is. It has only been three years since they last saw each other, but stress has deepened the lines on his father’s face.

“No, It isn’t.” Galeedeus sighs.

Oberon hesitates, not wanting to say the wrong thing.

“Father,” he starts carefully, “What if you are making a mistake?”

Galeedeus looks at Oberon, his eyebrow raised.

“I just mean to say... these plots and schemes you mention. What if they are nothing but air? I understand that the other Houses are brawling over scraps, but that does not mean we are caught up in some grand design.”

Galeedeus assesses his son slowly. “They do not fight over scraps, Oberon. This threat is as real as the sun.”

“This threat is nothing but rumours.” He insists. “You swore an oath to your King. You are bound by honour to ensure this Kingdom does not fall into chaos. This plan, and whatever you hope will come after it, will destroy the bonds that unite us.”

“No,” Galeedeus responds delicately, “We are not united. Not while we allow corruption to spread among our peers. I know my oath, son, but chaos has already taken this Kingdom.”

Oberon clenches his fists, trying to keep a cool head.

“And that releases you from your duty?” he blurts out, wincing a little at the impropriety, but too enraged to stop himself. “You once stood above all others, as a pillar of righteousness. But now you sink to the level of rebels. Planning treason in the very city of your King.”

Galeedeus grabs Oberon’s arm and pulls him close. His eyes are alight with fire.

“Do not repeat what you have just said to anyone. Anyone!” Galeedeus growls. “I know that this is difficult for you, son. But you have to accept that we are in serious danger. I cannot have you making it worse.”

“Worse?” Oberon snaps, “I have been fighting for this family! I spent three years at war for this family! I almost died for this family! I killed for this family!”

“And now you must protect your family!” Galeedeus shouts, “Accept your role, hold your tongue, and do what you must!”

Oberon glares at his father. His blood, still boiling with rage. But he feels a deep fear grow in his mind. He sees a future that he cannot avoid. Where he is back in the blood, and the pain, and the screams. His rage quickly leaves him.

“Father, please, I can’t lose this family again.” he finally admits, the reality of it shocking him. “You have to show that you are a true friend to the Vienna’s. Follow your oath. Bring these concerns to the High Conduits, to your King. Let them help you, because if you don’t they will ensure we all see their justice.”

Galeedeus’ furious eyes fall into shock. He doesn’t reply for a long moment. He just observes Oberon, tapping his finger against the pommel of his side sword as he does.

“You’re one of the most talented Knights the King has.” Galeedeus says slowly, “That, and your closeness to Lady Iya will keep you safe.”

Oberon thinks she would disagree with that after their fight last night. But he keeps that thought to himself. Galeedeus sighs, and turns back to the window once again.

“But I will follow through with this plan, son. I will protect this family. ”

That is the end of the discussion. Oberon can tell when his father has made up his mind. And good luck to anyone who tries to surpass his stubbornness. So, without another word, he just turns away from his father and leaves the room.